DESIGN SAMPLE · NARRATIVE AND SYSTEMS

Feeling a character's state through movement

A prototype from *The Chronicles of Demise*, my narrative RPG concept in Unreal Engine 5. The question: how can the player **feel** what the character feels, without a line of text telling them?

Design goal. When the character is anxious, moving should feel heavy and hesitant; when she is determined, it should feel light and fast. The world's colour should follow her mood. The change must be readable within a second and reversible when the moment passes.

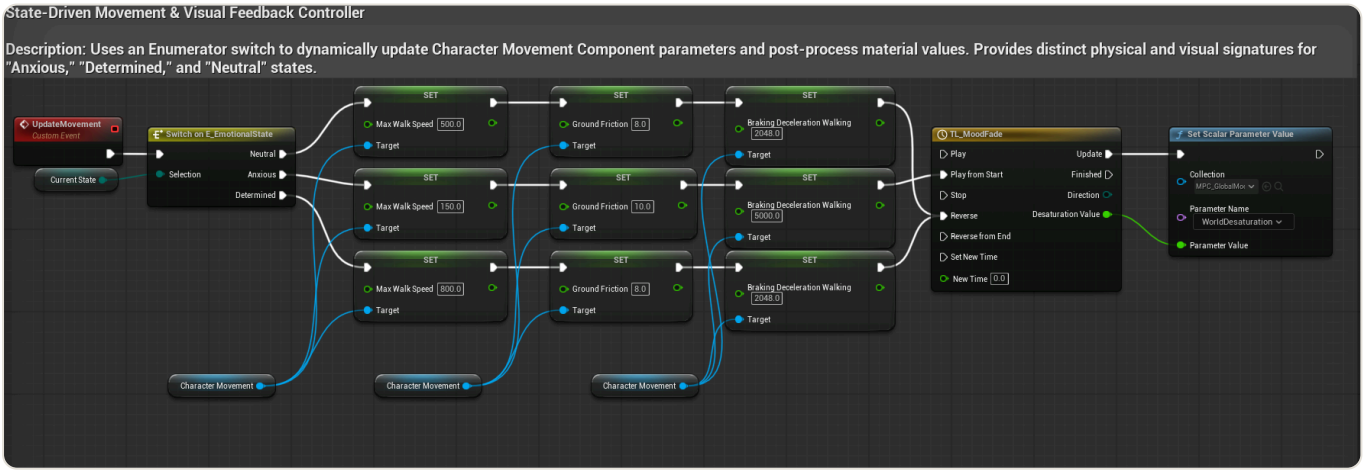
The three states

STATE	MAX WALK SPEED	GROUND FRICTION	BRAKING	WHAT THE PLAYER SHOULD FEEL
Neutral	500	8	2048	The baseline: responsive, unremarkable.
Anxious	150	10	5000	Heavy and hesitant. Every step is short and stops abruptly; the world drains of colour.
Determined	800	8	2048	Momentum. Faster than normal, so pushing forward feels earned.

Values are Unreal Character Movement Component settings (speed in cm/s, braking deceleration in cm/s²).

Why these numbers

- **Anxious cuts speed by 70%** and more than doubles braking. Slowness alone could read as "tired"; the abrupt stops are meant to read as "hesitant".
- **Determined is 60% faster** than neutral rather than double, to feel like momentum while staying easy to control.
- Friction changes only slightly, so steering stays familiar and the mood shows in starting and stopping.



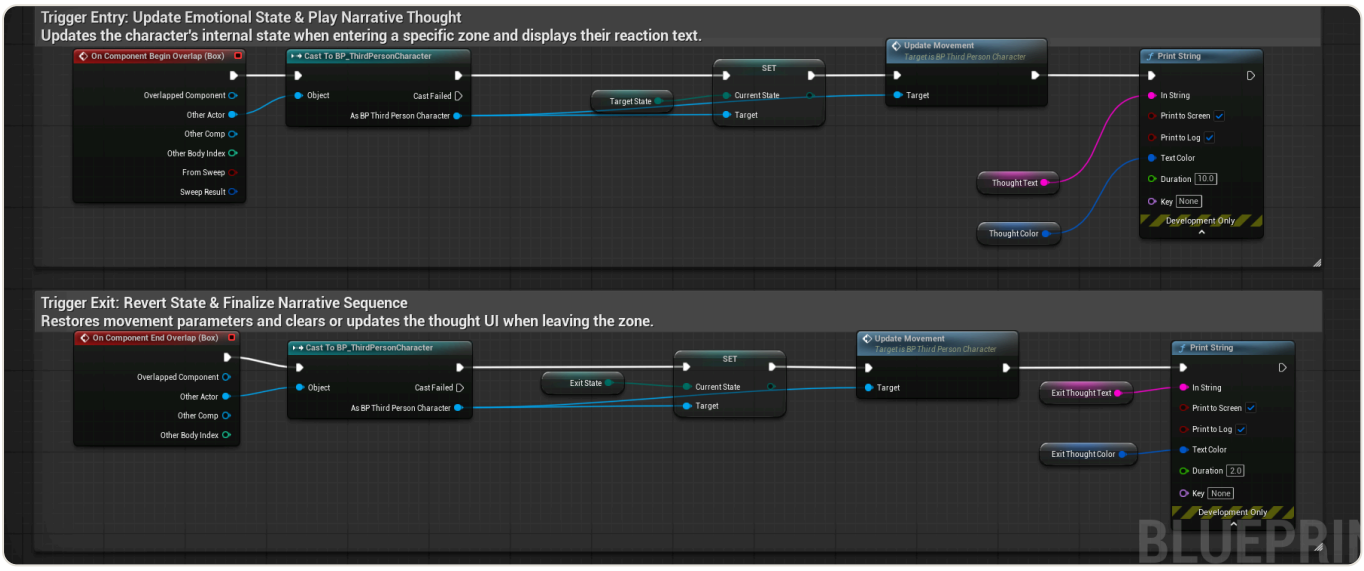
State-driven movement controller (Blueprint): a switch on the emotional state sets speed, friction and braking, then a timeline fades a global desaturation parameter.

HOW IT WORKS

One reusable trigger, set up by designers

The whole sequence runs from a single reusable trigger zone. Each placed copy has its own editable settings, so a level designer can script new emotional beats across a level without writing new logic.

1. **Enter the zone:** set the character's state (for example Anxious) and show a line of inner thought.
2. **Update movement:** apply that state's speed, friction and braking.
3. **Update the world:** a timeline fades a global material parameter, draining saturation over about a second.
4. **Leave the zone:** restore the exit state, fade colour back and show the closing thought.



Trigger entry and exit (Blueprint). The thought text uses a debug print for now; it is a placeholder for real UI.

Design considerations

- Movement is felt instantly, colour a beat later, so the two should change together.
- Slow zones should be short: long stretches of slow walking risk becoming a chore rather than a feeling.
- States must be exclusive and always reversible, so overlapping zones can never leave the character stuck.

Next tests

- Replace the debug text with diegetic UI (handwritten thoughts at screen edge).
- Playtest: can players name the character's mood from movement alone, with no text?
- Blend between states over 0.3–0.5 s instead of switching instantly.
- Add audio: breathing and footsteps that follow the state.

Honest scope. This is a small prototype built on a mid-range laptop GPU, with the Unreal mannequin and placeholder text. It tests one idea, not a production feature.

SYSTEMS DESIGN

Two rules of "The Canvas"

The Canvas is the first world of the game: a reality made of oil paint. Its rules turn that fiction into mechanics.

1. Paint drag and the Trial of Slowness

Rule	Thick paint slows the player; thin paint lets them move freely. Moving faster than the world's "drying time" smears the character, and staying over that speed resets them to the last safe point.
Player goal	Cross the Temple of Vesta by reading where the paint is thin and controlling speed, not by rushing.
Feedback	Visible brush thickness on the floor; the character's outline starts to blur before the reset, as a warning.
Failure	A short, non-punishing reset to the room's entrance, so the lesson is "slow down", not "start over".
Tuning knobs	Speed threshold, warning time before reset, drag per paint thickness, room length.
Why	It teaches patience through the controls, which is the theme of the level.

2. Integrity against Expression

Collecting a Sacred Seal lets the Canvas rewrite the character: magic reaches further, but the body becomes paint.

STAT	EFFECT OF EACH SEAL	DESIGN INTENT
Expression (magic)	Range and radius of spells grow	Power the player can see and use
Integrity (health)	Maximum health drops; weaker against Rot, the enemy's damage type	A real cost, so taking a Seal is a decision
Dialogue	Plain, factual answers are replaced by metaphors	The story shows the change too

Risk and mitigation. If every player simply takes every Seal, the choice is fake. Seals should be optional and placed before fights where range matters, so a careful player can reasonably skip one. That is the first thing I would playtest.

NARRATIVE TO MECHANICS

Every rule starts in the story

IN THE FICTION	MECHANIC	WHAT THE PLAYER EXPERIENCES
The Canvas is made of paint	Paint drag: movement speed depends on paint thickness	Reading the floor becomes route-finding
Rushing ruins wet paint	Speed threshold with a smear warning and reset	A patience trial that teaches through controls
Seals rewrite who you are	Expression up, Integrity down, dialogue changes	A power-for-fragility trade-off
Fear makes the world heavy	Emotional states change movement and colour	Feeling the character's mood directly
The Sector runs on logic	A grey, shadowless look and precise, grid-like spaces	A clear contrast when the story moves to the Canvas

Writing sample

From chapter 2 of the manuscript, the moment the hero is sentenced and cast out of the Sector:

> ***The world did not breathe here. It ticked. There was no sun to paint the sky in hues of melancholy; there was only the infinite, leaden ceiling of the Sector, illuminated by the harsh, shadowless glare of the fluorescent nebulas. Here, existence was not a canvas. It was a grid.***

In the game this becomes a level transition: the grid's grey, shadowless lighting and wide-angle camera give way to the warm, painterly Canvas and a softer lens, so the player sees the change of worlds rather than reads it.

Look test



A painterly look test in Unreal Engine 5 using an anisotropic Kuwahara filter, which groups pixels into brush-like strokes that follow the shapes in the scene.

Target for production: stroke direction that follows geometry, thicker paint in important places and lighting with strong light and dark contrast.